"harami" *well. He is a cat with nine lives. But, we will not let him get away this time. See to it that he is despatched to his God,' said the leader with a chuckle*.

'Hello Zulu 1, "Phantom" leaving for "Taj Mahal" now…. ETA [expected time of arrival] 0950 hours … over,' was the cryptic transmission by Captain Suresh Kumar, the general staff officer (intelligence) of the brigade, informing the Division HQ about my move.

'Yankee for Zulu 1 – roger out.'

Soon our convoy of four vehicles was snaking its way along the mountainous road. 'Move it,' I commanded the driver. The Nissan Patrol's two-litre engine revved up as the driver pressed on the accelerator.

'Don't you know that someone who moves slowly would be a f …..g dead duck, in this combat zone.'

'Yes sir,' was the prompt reply.

In normal practice, the convoy was led by a 1-tonner that carried the leading protection detachment of six soldiers. A machine gun was fitted on a bracket in the front with a swivel mounting, so that it could be fired in any direction. The commander of this detachment sat in the front cab, hawk-eyed and ever alert. A similar detachment was mounted in the other 1-tonner at the tail of the convoy. Sandwiched between them was my Nissan jonga and the Rover jeep (communication vehicle). I am convinced that in war, to do the expected or being predictable means disaster. Therefore, I did my best to achieve an element of surprise. 'The terrorist could appear from anywhere, and what is worse – at any time,' I would often remind my officers. 'Remember, that's the reason I am ready for action day or night and I and this loaded AK-47 are inseparable,' pointing towards my gun.

The convoy halted after taking a sharp turn five kilometres short of Baramulla. 'All seems quiet today, Sir,' said Captain Suresh, with a twinkle in his eye. Belonging to the artillery, he, apart from Captain V.K. Singh of the Education Corps, had seen more bullets being fired at him than many infantry officers. These youngsters were always brimming with enthusiasm and itching to prove their